the only way changes could be achieved was to persuade JRD to bring them about. JRD alone had the personality to steer them.

Ratan convinced Jamshed J. Bhabha (who rose from being personal assistant to JRD to MD of TISCO) and S.A. Sabavala (who rose from the post of executive assistant to JRD to being a director in Tata Industries Limited [TIL] and Tata Sons) to see his line of reasoning. On 7 March 1978, the three sent a note to JRD with their separate perspectives on the problems faced by the Tata Group and the changes needed. All three argued that the adoption of immediate measures was a matter of existential importance for the group.

The part of the note authored by Ratan was remarkable for its overarching group perspective. It asserted that the group companies were functioning as ‘diversified fragments of a common name’. Consequently, ‘common goals’ were often compromised. If the group had to secure its future, there was a need to ‘arrest and reverse’ this ‘drift’ resulting from the various companies pulling in ‘different directions’, he argued. In the absence of a group-level approach, the leaders of existing companies were determining the directions of their organizations, which often led to them adopting strategies and measures that ran contrary to the group’s ethos and principles.

Tata Sons had low holdings in most of its companies. The group companies were known as Tata companies because Tata Sons was their promoter. The low holdings exposed the group to the danger of a renegade leader of a large company severing it from the promoter. There was also the serious threat of the companies dissociating from the group with the help of other business houses.

Ratan urged JRD to formulate ‘strategic plans for the group as a whole’ that would enable the Tata directors and executives to ‘begin once again to see a direction and gain a sense of motivation and belonging’. He urged that steps be taken for ‘reclaiming’ the perception of the group as the ‘most progressive and growth-oriented industrial house in the country’.

He implored JRD to ‘spare the time and give the firm the benefit’ of his ‘active involvement in its present and future operations’. He said categorically that only JRD could ‘rekindle the unity and the vitality that the Firm once had’. As Ratan had hoped, the letter evoked an immediate response from JRD. A meeting was scheduled to be held within a fortnight. For a more meaningful discussion, Ratan prepared two additional